

Confederate riposte

By mid-morning, some of Longstreet's men had discovered an unfinished railroad cut to the south and, concealed from view, turned Hancock's flank, rolling it up brigade by brigade until the Union troops were in mass retreat. In the din and confusion, some Confederates saw horses galloping toward them through the smoke and leveled a volley. Among the men and animals left sprawled on the ground were South Carolina's General Micah Jenkins, shot in the head, and Lee's "Old War Horse," Longstreet himself, severely wounded in the neck.

With that the Southern attack faltered; when it was renewed in late afternoon, it was decisively repulsed by Federal troops deployed behind breastworks along Brock Road. A roar of musketry to the north was that of John B. Gordon's Georgians trying to outflank the Union right, but the shooting slackened with darkness, with neither side able to break through. A second terrible night descended on the burning, bullet-shredded Wilderness. Grant called off his attacks; Lee dug in.

By dawn on May 7, with both armies well entrenched and the fighting ended for the moment, Grant had made the decision not to retreat, as his predecessors had too often done when faced with a setback. Rather, he planned to slide left and south, ordering the Army of the Potomac's high command to strike that evening for Spotsylvania Court House, a hamlet located some 10 miles (16km) to the southeast of the Wilderness battlefield. It stood at a crossroads that controlled the routes to Richmond.

Grant was determined to position his forces between Lee and the Confederate capital. He knew this was the only way he could compel the enemy to fight in the open, and he did not want to see Lee's outnumbered veterans get behind breastworks. Prying them out would lead to costly fighting.

Grant hoped to begin his maneuver around Lee's right flank without being detected by his adversary. He slipped most of the army behind Hancock's Second Corps, still manning the Brock Road and thus masking the movement. The press of wagons and